Assessing Joint Committee Rules Reform

Findings from the Beacon Hill Compliance Tracker

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https://BeaconHillTracker.org/
PDM Rules Reform Forum • April 17, 2026

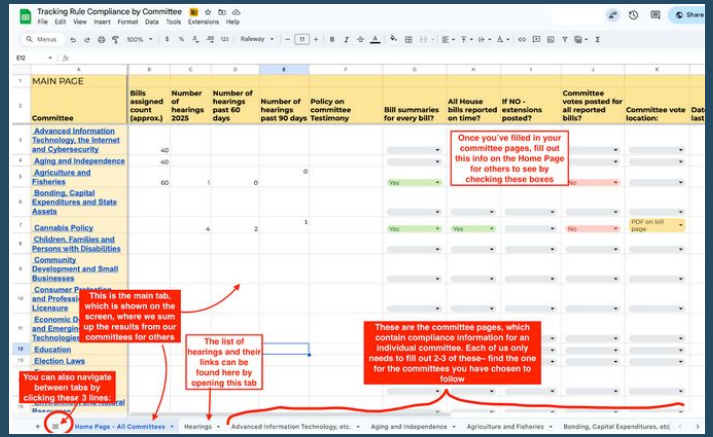
The Need for a Tracker

In 2025, the Massachusetts Legislature adopted new **Joint Rules** aimed at increasing **transparency**.

"These critical reforms are representative of the House's strong commitment to the pursuit of a more accessible and efficient Legislature that is responsive to the concerns of our constituents."

- *House Speaker Ronald J. Mariano (D-Quincy)*

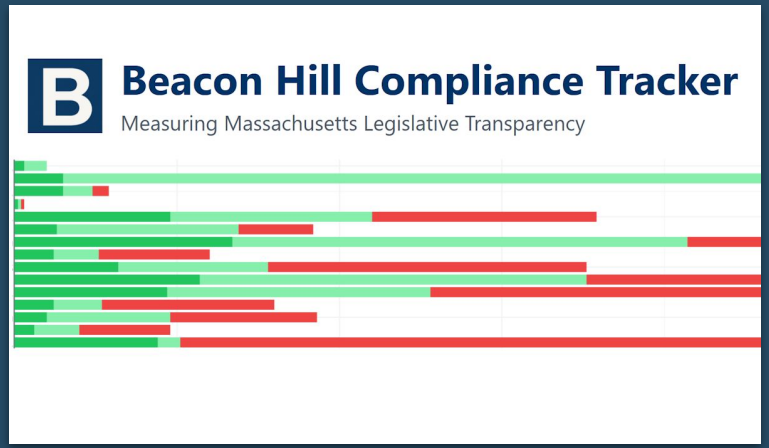
Tracking **new Joint Rules** for **31 Joint Committees** across **thousands of bills** with **dozens of hearings** and **scattered documentation** through **ever-evolving timelines** *by hand* proved to be a herculean task:



What the Tracker Measures

An automated Tracker was built to follow four main rules:

1. **10 days' advance notice** for hearings
2. **Summaries** for every bill
3. Earlier **reporting deadlines**
4. Publicly posted **votes**

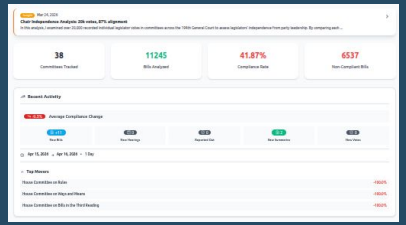


*The Tracker checks the **Legislature's website** for evidence of **compliance with its own rules.***

How the Tracker works

```python
if days_notice >= notice_requirement:
    notice_desc = f"adequate notice ({days_notice} days)"
    return RuleResult(
        passed=Status.COMPLIANT,
        reason=f"Notice requirement met (days' notice: {days_notice})",
        notice_description=notice_desc,
    )
```

```python
REFERRED = "REFERRED"
DISCHARGED = "DISCHARGED"
REPORTED = "REPORTED"
STUDY_ORDER = "STUDY_ORDER"
ACCOMPANIED = "ACCOMPANIED"
HEARING_SCHEDULED = "HEARING_SCHEDULED"
```



1. **Every night**, discovers all bills with URLs
2. Parses each bill's history to calculate **deadlines**
3. Crawls site looking for **votes** & **summaries**
4. Runs findings through **rules algorithm**
5. Posts final **compliance assessment** to site

Overall Compliance Rate

As of April 16, 2026…

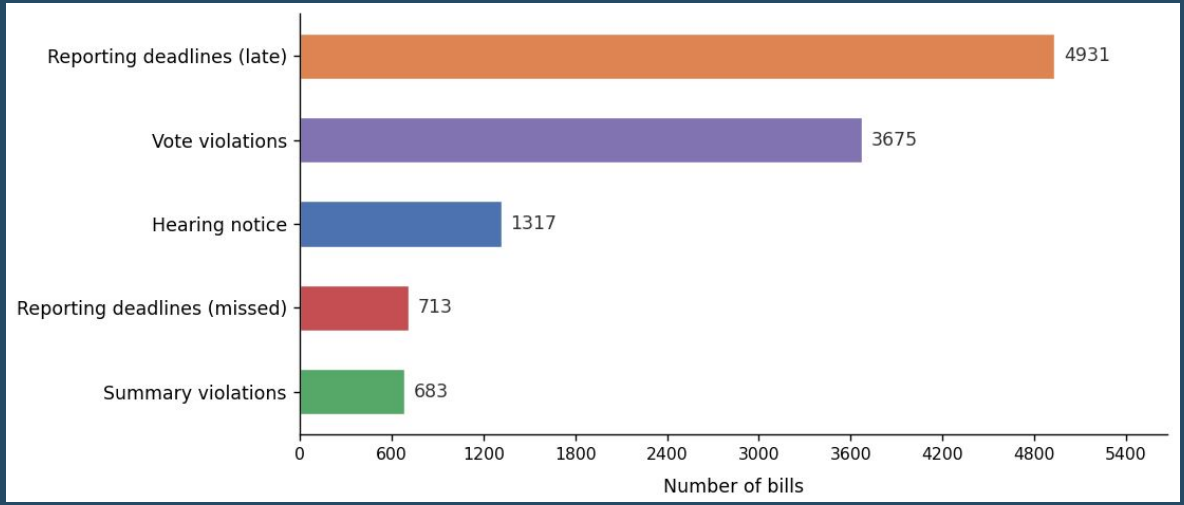
44.64%

Compliance Rate

…across over 7,300 bills.

Anatomy of Non-Compliance

As of April 14, 2026



N.B.: *One bill can break multiple rules. This chart represents "times this rule was broken", not "number of bills that broke this rule".*

The Receipts

It's not necessary to parse <u>every</u> number I'm about to present.

But I think it's important to show what we found.

Bill Summary Violations • 683

*Summaries of bills in advance of hearings give **citizens** and **legislators** a chance to quickly decide if a bill is relevant to them.*

Joint Committee	Violations
Labor & Workforce Development	122
Education	107
State Admin. & Regulatory Oversight	86
Revenue	78
Judiciary	43

Chamber	Violations
House	629
Senate	54

Hearing Notice Violations • 1,317

*Hearing notice gives the **public, stakeholders, and opposing interests** time to prepare, organize, and testify.*

Joint Committee	Violations
Judiciary	220
Financial Services	157
State Admin. & Regulatory Oversight	136
Public Service	132
Education	115

Chamber	Violations
House	845
Senate	472

Committee Vote Violations • 3,675

Publicly posted votes allow the public to ***understand how their legislators voted*** *and hold them accountable.*

Joint Committee	Violations
Judiciary	649
Revenue	355
Financial Services	291
Public Service	278
Education	257

Chamber	Violations	Favorable
House	2,930	1,018
Senate	745	1,134

For bills with vote records, bills were sent to study 1,088 times (33.6% of the time).

Reporting Deadline Violations • 5,644

*Deadlines force committees to **make a decision** – pass, amend, or reject – on the record, promoting action on bills and accountability.*

Joint Committee	Violations
Judiciary	50 + 669 = 719
Public Service	11 + 438 = 449
Financial Services	25 + 406 = 431
Revenue	60 + 324 = 384
Education	185 + 178 = 363

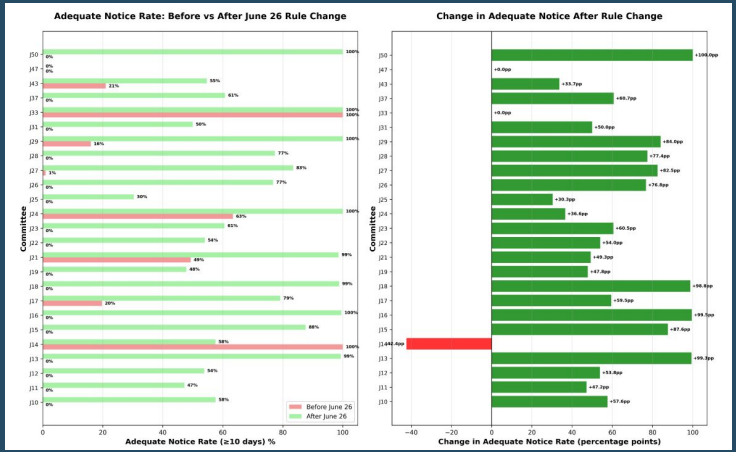
Chamber	Violations
House	582 + 3,543 = 4,125
Senate	131 + 1,388 = 1,519

The first number in each equation is “no action” bills; the second number is “late” bills.

Did the Rules Change Anything?

Yes!

- **Hearing notice** had the most drastic change
- Bills were reported out **late** more often than they were **buried**
- Summaries were posted over **92% of the time**



Left: *Red bars indicate 10 days' advance notice before the new rule, green bars show post-rule effect.*
Right: *The increase in advance notice by committee after the new rules.*

What Are the Gaps?

- Documentation is **extremely inconsistent**
- The only **trackers** are 100% external
- The rules have lots of **workarounds**

There's still work ahead – still, this is **progress.**

What's the Takeaway?

- The rules made a real **impact** on workflows
- **Compliance** is good, **transparency** is better
- Productivity is now a **trackable** metric

New rules got us this far; what to do with the **results?**

Where Do We Go From Here?

There are a few ways to contribute, in ascending order of investment:

- Low
  - Visit the Tracker, **look your reps' committees up**
  - **Forward committees' compliance data** to advocates

- Medium
  - Contact your legislators, **cite specific numbers**
  - Ask whether they plan to vote "yes" on the **stipend reform ballot question**

- High
  - Vote "yes" on the stipend reform ballot question in **November**
  - **Talk** to local civic groups, town Democrat/Republican committees, etc. **about the data**

Thank you!

Special thanks to Jon Cohn, Scotia Hille, and Jon Hecht

Reach me at **info@beaconhilltracker.org**